

The physical world

Just under 30 percent of Earth's surface is land, mostly contained in giant continental landmasses. Around the seven continents, tens of thousands of islands are scattered across the world's seas and oceans. People have been exploring and mapping the globe for thousands of years, to chart its wealth of natural features and mark their place in the world.

Horizontal lines of latitude show how many degrees north or south places are from the equator.

ANDES MOUNTAINS

Running through seven countries on the west coast of South America, the Andes form the longest mountain range in the world. More than 4,500 miles (7,000 km) long and up to 199 miles (320 km) wide, the Andes are rich in metals and also contain most of South America's volcanoes.



VICTORIA FALLS

Around 39.5 million gallons (180 million liters) of water flows over Victoria Falls every minute. Located on the Zambezi River in southern Africa, the waterfall is 5,500 ft (1.68 km) wide and 355 ft (108 m) high.